

accepted that his job was to provide entertainment for audiences that appreciated melodrama and strong emotion rather than subtlety. By 1850, he had completed 15 operas, complaining that he had to work “like a galley slave.”

In the early 1850s, Verdi wrote three masterpieces that have stood the test of time: *Rigoletto*, *La traviata*, and *Il trovatore*. These were works that built on the *bel canto* (literally, “beautiful singing”) tradition of his Italian predecessors Rossini, Bellini, and Donizetti, but with greater dramatic power and an element of social and political provocation. *Rigoletto* ran into trouble with the censors because it depicted a dissolute and wicked ruler, implicitly questioning monarchical authority. *La traviata*, based on Alexandre Dumas’ recent novel *La Dame aux Camélias*, was considered shocking for its sympathy with a fallen woman “living in sin” with her lover.

The theme of *La traviata* was of direct relevance to the composer himself, who was sharing his life, unmarried, with Streponi. In 1851, in accordance with his image of himself as a simple man of the people, he returned to his native countryside, where he began occupying a villa that he had built at Sant’Agata, just outside Busseto. The local people perceived Verdi’s cohabitation with Streponi as sinful. Utterly irreligious, he made plain his absolute contempt for their narrow-mindedness and when the municipality sought to profit from his celebrity by creating a theater named for him, Verdi refused to even step inside the building. However, he did eventually marry Streponi in 1859.

Italy’s adoption of Verdi as a hero of the Risorgimento (see